Cyberlink and AMD
The two companies will work hand-in-hand to improve performance using Stream and DirectX 11

320 GB Blu-ray
TDK announces 320GB optical discs which can be played on Blu-ray drives

ZOTAC's duo of GTX 285s are faster than the other cards in this price range and quite understandably so since both feature high-end GPUs with a full 240 stream processors. If you're shopping for a card within this price range you'd probably be best off settling for a ZOTAC GTX 285 – the winner of our *Best Buy* award. Priced at Rs. 21,000 it blows away everything at a similar price.

High-end cards above Rs. 24,500

This price point is where we start to get dreamy-eyed as all the big guns come out. Admittedly, super high-end cards are the most expensive, but paradoxically manufacturers also make the biggest losses selling them. This is because both NVIDIA and ATi load their biggest, most technologically advanced GPUs on these cards and it is here that the pinnacle of today's technology is found. Two GPUs on a single PCB, 512-bit memory buses and other similarly tantalising goodies are to be found here. No wonder, margins are slim. To be honest, it was surprising to see ZOTACs GTX 285 cards well below this price point, kudos to them. But it was another entrant that had us all wet-palmed with excitement: the new Radeon HD 5870 GPU from AMD. Codenamed 'Cypress', there were three of these DX 11 offerings around, one each from ASUS and Sapphire and one reference card from AMD. The Radeon HD 5870 also has a neat cooler – very long, encase entirely in a plastic shroud but owing to the 40 nm process the card doesn't get as hot as its predecessors. While on the topic of monster cards, the GTX 295 is a dual-GPU setup featuring two GTX 285 GPUs (at lower clock speeds) and a massive 1792 MB of DDR3 VRAM. The older Radeon HD 4870 x2 is also around, and ASUS had two cards based on this solution. One of which had one of the most massive looking cooling solutions we've seen, with a large heatsink and three large fans. Needless to say, the 4870 x2 heats up quite a lot and the stock cooling solution doesn't really cut it, making ASUS' innovative heatsink a godsend. XFX also uses a unique cooler on their GTX 295 that looks very similar to the cooling solution on the NVIDIA 7900 GTX of old. There is a full-length heatsink with heatpipes and the fan is larger than the stock GTX 295 fan and placed in the middle.

With double the shader units of its predecessor, the Radeon HD 5870 is furiously fast, and easily the fastest single-GPU solution till date. It is easily faster than the NVIDIA GTX 285 solutions although it still cannot manage an average fps of 30 running *Crysis Warhead* on either of our test resolutions. Similarly *Clear Sky* is also choppy – it's not often that older generation

ZOTAC GeForce GTX 295

games do this to latest hardware but it has happened, whether a result of improper, inefficient coding, or engines that classify as before-their-time or whatever, the fps numbers dip before our eyes. Throughout the tests, the GTX 295-based cards are faster by varying margins. Even the HD 4870 x2 cannot manage 30+ fps in *Warhead* at 1920 x 1200 pixels, but the GTX 295 skids past this figure (but only just).

Older games are a cakewalk with these cards, but what's more important is that cards based on the GTX 295, 4870 x2 and 5870 should be able to run most upcoming games. Of course, every category has to have a shining star and ATi's new Cypress is it. That a single GPU card can hold its own amid dual-GPU monsters is testament to its pedigree. It's also the first DX 11 card available, so future proofing should not be an issue. Obviously, these are early days, and NVIDIA promises a DX 11 monster of their own early next year, but for now the HD 5870 rules supreme. But wait! – didn't we just say the GTX 295 cards were faster? Well, true, but it's not always about raw fps values. The Radeon HD 5870 is the future and will definitely spawn faster variants. AMD is reportedly working on 'Hemlock' a dual GPU 5870 variant which will surely be faster than the GTX 295. We also noticed better visual quality with the Radeon HD 5870, just like the 5770 in the mid-range category. Add to this support for DX 11 – a little future proofing can't hurt! Although the difference is minor, it's

Choices and decisions

You Need
The fastest single graphics card on the planet at the moment

We Recommend


ZOTAC GeForce GTX 295
Rs. 30,500

Things to check
Your power supply. This should be at least 600 watts and of a good brand

You Need
A high-end GPU that is also future proof and not astronomically priced

We Recommend


Sapphire Radeon HD 5870
Rs. 26,000

Things to check
At least a 500-watt power supply from a reputed brand

You Need
A gaming graphics card within a budget of Rs. 10,000

We Recommend


Sapphire Radeon HD 4850
Rs. 6,300

Things to check
A decent 450-watt power supply should suffice. And make sure your board has a PCIe slot

You Need
The best gaming card for a price of Rs. 15,000

We Recommend


XFX HD-489A-ZDD7
Rs. 14,500

Things to check
A 500-watt power supply and a well ventilated cabinet – this baby can get hot!